



Tennessee Summer Nutrition Initiative

Policy 24.31

Effective: June 1, 2026

Introduction

The goal of the Tennessee Department of Human Services (TDHS) 2026 Tennessee Summer Nutrition Initiative (TSNI) is to supplement nutritional assistance in counties with lack of access to Summer Food Service Program (SFSP) or other supplemental summer feeding program options. Children who reside in these counties and who rely on the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) and Families First, the State's Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF) program for nutritional assistance often struggle to obtain adequate food resources after schools close.

To address this challenge, the TDHS will issue a one-time cash benefit of \$120 per qualifying child in SNAP and Families First households across thirteen (13) counties with limited access to SFSP feeding sites for immediate access to funds for nutritional purchases. The thirteen (13) counties eligible for this one-time issuance were selected following analysis of Summer 2025 SFSP and Tennessee Department of Education Seamless Summer Option (SSO) program data available from USDA. TDHS determined through this analysis that there were five (5) or fewer open SFSP/SSO sites available in these counties.

This benefit is scheduled for distribution via Electronic Benefits Transfer (EBT) in June 2026. To minimize barriers to access nutritional support, no application is required for children in SNAP and Families First households to participate. TSNI benefits will be automatically credited to existing EBT accounts on the designated issuance date.

Scope

The purpose of this policy is to provide an overview of the TSNI program including benefit amount, eligibility criteria, and issuance, notification, and appeal procedures.

Policy

Benefit Amount

Each eligible child will receive a one-time benefit of \$120.00.

Eligibility

Qualifying families will receive a one-time payment of \$120.00 for each eligible school-aged child.

1. The child must be included in an open and active SNAP and/or Families First case as of May 31, 2026. Cases where the certification period ends on May 31, 2026 are eligible.
2. The child must be included in a SNAP and/or Families First case which is designated in the Eligibility Benefits Management System (EBMS) as residing in Bledsoe, Cannon, Clay, DeKalb, Fentress, Hancock, Humphreys, Jackson, Lewis, Marshall, Moore, Sequatchie, and Smith Counties as of May 31, 2026.
3. The child must be at least five (5) years old but not older than eighteen (18) years old as of May 1, 2026. Children whose birthdates fall between May 2, 2007 and May 1, 2021 are eligible.

Children must meet all eligibility criteria to receive a TSNi benefit.

No application is required to receive a TSNi benefit, nor will TDHS accept applications to facilitate issuance of benefits. Each eligible child will automatically receive the benefit via their household's existing EBT card.

Issuance

A one-time benefit will be automatically issued to each eligible child's household's existing EBT account in June 2026. The household will receive the benefit in a lump sum payment for all eligible children in the household. FIS, the State's current EBT vendor, has confirmed the State's proposed issuance timeline.

Issuance will be documented in case notes for all households receiving a TSNi benefit.

Notification to Customers

TDHS will generate and mail notices of the issuance to each household with at least one eligible child. Each notice will include information about eligibility criteria and the timeframe to file an appeal.

Beneficiaries will also receive automated text message notifications regarding the issuance.

Program Violations

TDHS will make reasonable efforts to detect over-issuances and improper payments. These efforts will include utilizing established methods and channels to receive tips, complaints, and referrals regarding TSNi activity. TDHS will coordinate with relevant state agencies and local authorities for case data collection and analysis, conduct follow up inquiries as appropriate, and pursue claims as appropriate.

Appeals

Appeals concerning TSNi benefits must be filed within thirty (30) days of benefit issuance to be considered timely.

Appeals will only be accepted from clients who allege meeting the eligibility requirements below:

- Households with an open and active SNAP and/or Families First case as of May 31, 2026, that are designated in EBMS as residing in one of the eligible counties; and
- Households with at least one child age 5-18, as of May 1, 2026, included in the open and active SNAP and/or Families First case.

Appeals will be completed through desk review of written material only. A DHS Administrative Judge will review the written material submitted by both parties and will issue a Desk Review Order. Desk Review Orders are the final administrative determination and petitions to the Department regarding such decisions will not be accepted. A person who is aggrieved by the Desk Review Order may petition the court for judicial review in Chancery Court of the county of residence or in Davidson County within sixty (60) days of the entry date of the Final Order. See [Tenn. Code Ann. § 4-5-317](#) and [Tenn. Code Ann. § 4-5-322](#).

Supporting Documents

[Tenn. Code Ann. § 4-5-317](#)

[Tenn. Code Ann. § 4-5-322](#)

Definitions/Acronyms

Term	Definition
EBMS	Eligibility Benefits Management System
EBT	Electronic Benefits Transfer
SFSP	Summer Food Service Program
SNAP	Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program
SSO	Seamless Summer Option
TANF	Temporary Assistance for Needy Families
TDHS	Tennessee Department of Human Services
TSNI	Tennessee Summer Nutrition Initiative

Supersedes

Policy 24.31 Tennessee Summer Nutrition Initiative, eff. date 06/01/2025

Authority

Chapter 530 of the Public Acts of 2025, Section 58, Item 6

Application

All Family Assistance employees

Revision History

Date	Version	Location of Change	Description/Reason for Change
05/26/2026	06/01/2026	Policy Section	This policy revision reduced the number of counties participating; updated the birthdates for eligible children.
04/28/2025	06/01/2025	New Policy	New Policy

Approval History

Approved By	Approver Title	Approved Date	Effective Date
Clarence H. Carter	Commissioner	05/26/2026	06/01/2026
Clarence H. Carter	Commissioner	04/28/2025	06/01/2025

Current Approver: